

stage of drilling, he showed he had no intention of doing any serious work that day and began to openly soldier on the job.

The other members of the crew watched closely to see what—if anything—I would do. Luckily, two things were in my favor. I, myself, had been out the night before and the crew knew this, and the hung-over goldbricker was only a few years older than I was.

"Feeling rough?" I asked him. He just glowered at me.

"I'll make you a deal," I went on. "I'll spot you ten seconds and race you up the rig. If you beat me, you can have the day off with pay."

100

The roustabout squinted up to the top of the drilling tower. "Boss, you're on," he grunted. I handed one of the other men my watch. At a signal, the roustabout started a monkey scramble up the rig. Exactly ten seconds later, I followed suit—and succeeded in reaching the crown block a second or two before him.

We were both winded when we got back down to the drilling platform—but it was obvious that I had won several victories. The other members of the crew were grinning broadly. I'd handled the situation in a manner that they could appreciate and had proved my right to be "boss." The roustabout was good-naturedly jeered—and he took it all in equally good stride.

"OK," he groaned. "I'll work this shift if it kills me!" He did work the shift—and it didn't kill him. Thereafter, he was one of the hardest-working and most conscientious members of the crew, and subsequently worked for me on many other drilling jobs.

I'll grant the incident is an elementary illustration of how applied psychology can solve management problems and help business operate more efficiently. I would hardly recommend that, say, the executive vice-president of a construction company enter into a hod-carrying competition with an apprentice bricklayer in order to prove his managerial bona fides. Nonetheless, the example serves to demonstrate that, in directing human